

LOOK WHO IS FLYING YOU

Homemakers to MBAs to businessmen, they are all donning pilots' overalls to cash in on the boom in the aviation sector

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

For nearly 20 years, Judith Bharathi, 40, climbed to the terrace of her three-storeyed residential building in Andheri East, Mumbai whenever she wanted to see airliners gliding down towards the airport. A few weeks from now, this homemaker will be strapped in the cockpit of a turboprop ATR aircraft, lowering flaps and reducing speed as it hits the runway.

It's been a lone journey for someone who grew up in a small village in

Kanyakumari district of Tamil Nadu and left her MSc midway to join her businessman husband in Mumbai. Last year, she forked out Rs 10 lakh to take flying lessons along with her 18-year-old daughter Baviya in Indore. "I did it for a sense of achievement," says the homemaker, who briefly considered an MBA while handling the accounts of her husband's workshop that services offset printing machines.

Bharathi is part of the changing profile of an Indian airline pilot. An industry growing at nearly 12 per cent annually and a perpetual shortage of

pilots has pushed their salaries to around Rs 2 lakh per month. Now the rising demand—Indian carriers fall short of at least 1,000 pilots to fly their new Boeings and Airbuses—is luring, businessmen, doctors, engineers and MBAs into the cockpits.

For Jai Kapadia, 29, joining his Indore-based family's garment export business seemed the most logical thing to do after obtaining his MBA from Pune's Neville Wadia Institute of Management. But after seven years of exporting readymade garments to Malaysia and Australia, he decided to don the flying overalls and train at a school nearby. He obtained his licence this August and is off to France to train on an Airbus aircraft. "I wanted to join the air force as a child," says Kapadia.

Last year, the Director-General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) handed out 368 commercial pilot licences (CPL) and

JUDITH BHARATHI, HOMEMAKER. She took flying lessons in Indore along with her 18-year-old daughter.

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